CORE TEN

# Exercise guide

Every move in the program: what it is, which muscles it works, how a beginner does it, what it should feel like, and the form fault that hurts backs. Based on Stuart McGill's "Big 3" (curl-up, side plank, bird dog) plus glute bridges and dead bugs, progressed over four blocks. Sessions are ten minutes.

■ Primary muscles ▢ Also working

## Block 1 · Foundation Weeks 1–4

Learn the brace and the three base patterns with perfect form.

**A:** Cat–Cow 60s · McGill Curl-Up 90s · Side Plank · Knees 90s · Bird Dog 90s · Glute Bridge 80s · Dead Bug 80s · Knees to Chest 60s

**B:** Pelvic Tilts 60s · Dead Bug 80s · Glute Bridge · Hold 90s · Side Plank · Knees 90s · Bird Dog 90s · Wall Hip Hinge 80s · Half-Kneel Hip Flexor 60s

## Block 2 · Build Weeks 5–8

Same patterns, more time under tension, first progressions.

**A:** Cat–Cow 45s · McGill Curl-Up · Elbows Up 90s · Side Plank · Knees 100s · Bird Dog 100s · Front Plank · Knees 80s · Dead Bug 80s · Child's Pose 45s

**B:** Pelvic Tilts 45s · Dead Bug · Heel Tap 90s · Glute Bridge · Hold 100s · Side Plank · Knees 90s · Bird Dog 90s · Hip Hinge · Reach 90s · Half-Kneel Hip Flexor 60s

## Block 3 · Strengthen Weeks 9–12

Harder variations. This is where the midsection visibly tightens.

**A:** Cat–Cow 40s · McGill Curl-Up · Elbows Up 90s · Side Plank · Feet 100s · Bird Dog · Sweep 100s · Front Plank 80s · Hollow Hold · Bent 80s · Child's Pose 45s

**B:** Pelvic Tilts 40s · Dead Bug · Heel Tap 90s · Single-Leg Bridge 100s · Side Plank · Feet 90s · Reverse Lunge 90s · Hip Hinge · Reach 80s · Figure-4 Stretch 60s

## Block 4 · Own It Week 13 onward

Keep the strength, add walking. Repeat until it's a habit you don't think about.

**A:** Cat–Cow 40s · McGill Curl-Up · Elbows Up 80s · Side Plank · Roll 100s · Bird Dog · Sweep 90s · Front Plank 80s · Hollow Hold · Bent 80s · Walk 60s

**B:** Pelvic Tilts 40s · Dead Bug · Heel Tap 80s · Single-Leg Bridge 100s · Side Plank · Feet 80s · Reverse Lunge 90s · Wall Sit 90s · Walk 60s

**Stop and see a doctor** if you get pain that shoots down a leg, numbness or tingling, weakness in a foot, pain that wakes you at night, or any change in bladder or bowel control. Sharp pain during a move is not something to work through: skip that move and note it.

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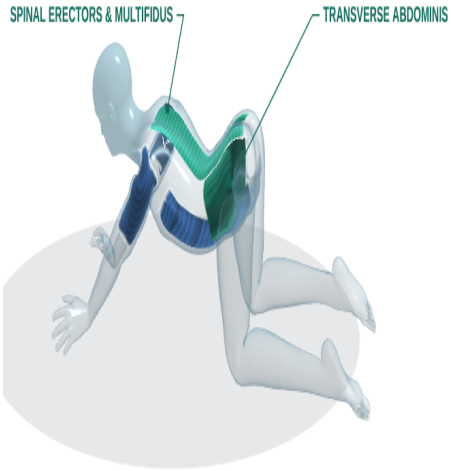

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# Cat–Cow

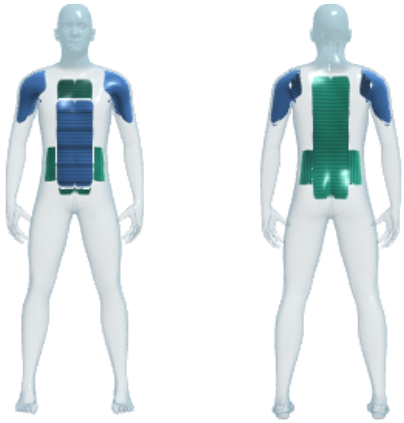
A gentle warm-up that moves the spine through its full curve: rounding up like a startled cat, then letting the belly drop like a cow's back.




**Start** Cat · tuck the tailbone, round up




**End** Cow · tailbone up, belly sinks



FRONT BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Spinal erectors & multifidus** · the low-back muscles either side of the spine

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

ALSO

**Rectus abdominis** · the front abs

**Shoulders** · deltoids and rotator cuff

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Movement through the whole spine, not a stretch in one spot. Warm, not sore.

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Hands under shoulders, knees under hips, back flat like a table.
2. Breathe out and push the floor away so the middle of your back rises. Let your head hang.
3. Breathe in and let the belly sink toward the floor while the chest lifts. Look slightly up.
4. Four slow counts each way. Small range beats big range.

## WATCH FOR

Forcing the low back into a deep arch on the cow.

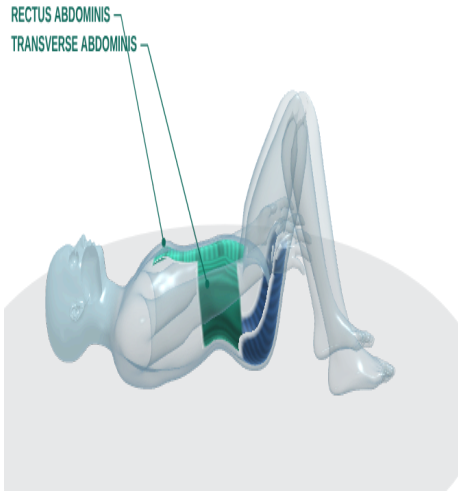
Doing it fast. It's a warm-up, not a rep count.

**Easier:** Do it sitting on a chair: round forward, then sit tall.

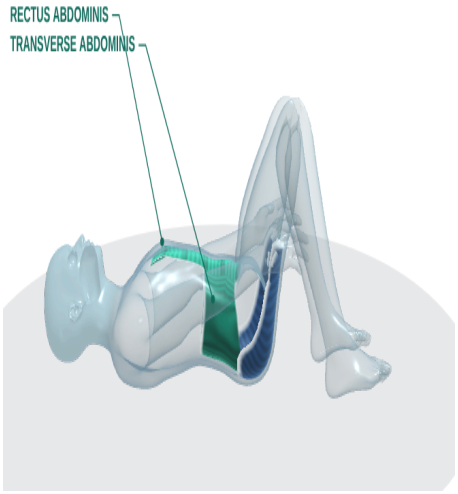
In the session: Slow. 4-count up, 4-count down. Move from the hips, not the neck.

# Pelvic Tilts

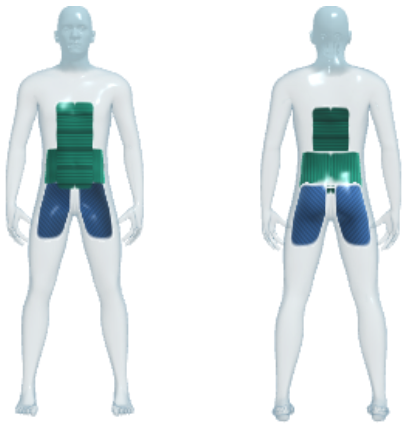
A tiny rock of the pelvis that teaches you to find and flatten the low back using the abs. This is the first skill every other move depends on.




**Start** Relaxed · small gap under the back




**End** Tilt · tuck the tailbone, flatten the back



FRONT BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

**Rectus abdominis** · the front abs

ALSO

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Lie on your back, knees bent, feet flat, arms at your sides.
2. Notice the small gap under your low back.
3. Tighten your abs and tuck your tailbone so the gap closes and the low back presses into the floor.
4. Hold three seconds, breathe, relax. Repeat slowly.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Low abs working. The low back flattens without the legs pushing.

## WATCH FOR

Pushing through the feet instead of using the abs.

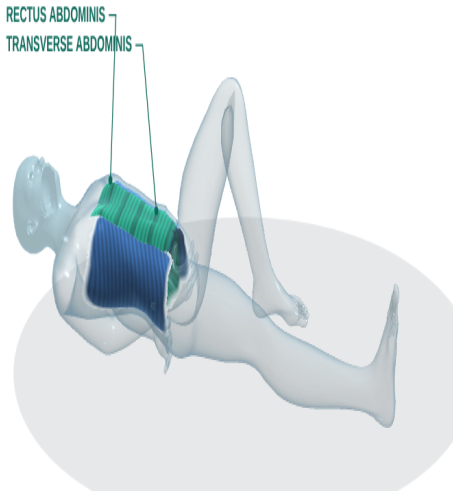
Holding your breath.

**Easier:** Put a hand under the low back and just squash the hand.

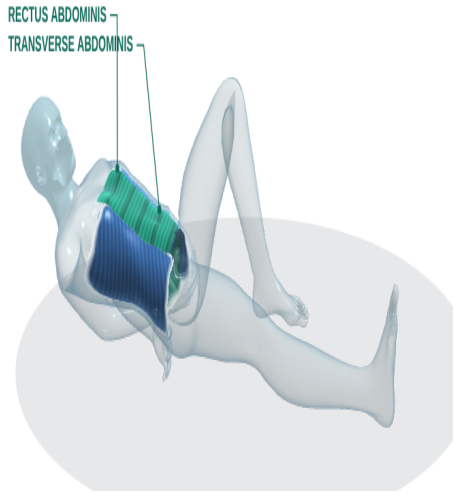
In the session: Slow reps for the whole time. Flatten, hold 3s, release.

# McGill Curl-Up

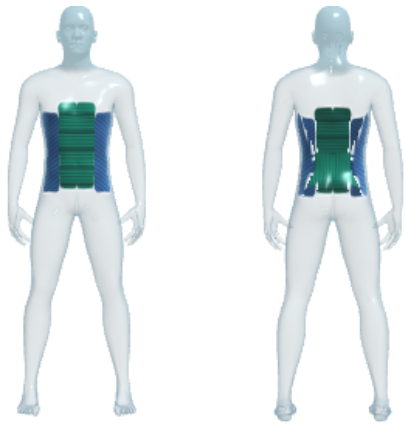
Stuart McGill's replacement for the sit-up. The spine stays still; you lift only the head and shoulders a finger-width, which loads the abs without bending the low back.




**Start** Set up · hands under the low back




**End** Lift head and shoulders an inch



FRONT BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Rectus abdominis** · the front abs

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

ALSO

**Obliques** · the sides of the waist

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Lie on your back. One knee bent, foot flat; the other leg straight.
2. Slide both hands under the small of your back to keep its natural curve.
3. Brace your abs as if someone is about to poke you.
4. Lift head and shoulders about an inch, as one unit. Hold ten seconds. Lower.
5. Rest three seconds. Repeat. Switch the bent knee halfway.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Front abs under tension. Neck relaxed, chin neutral.

## WATCH FOR

Tucking the chin or curling up high. This is not a crunch.

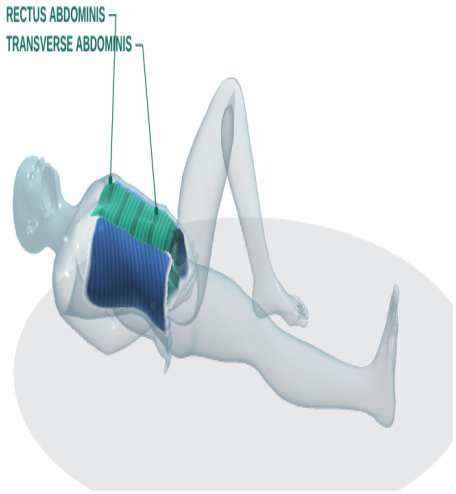
Flattening the back; the hands are there to stop that.

**Easier:** Hold five seconds instead of ten, or only lift the head.

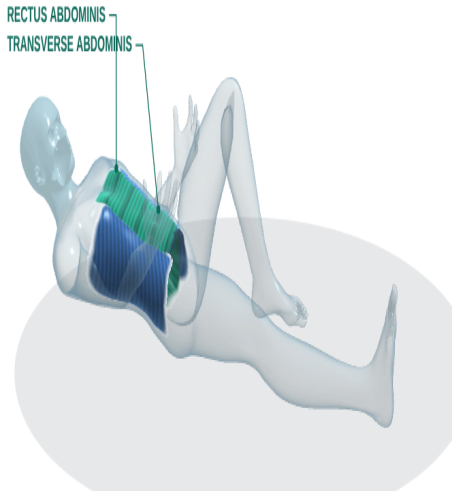
In the session: Hold 10s, rest 3s. Repeat. Switch bent knee halfway.

# McGill Curl-Up · Elbows Up

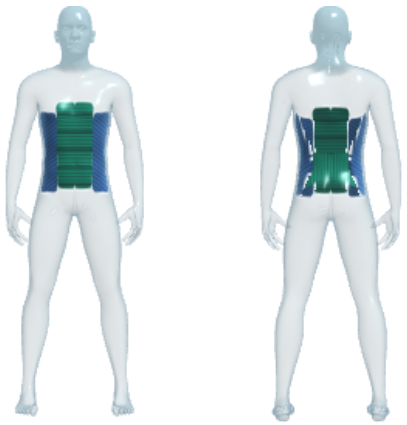
The same McGill curl-up with the elbows lifted an inch off the floor, so the abs carry all the load instead of sharing it with the arms.




**Start** Set up · hands under the low back




**End** Lift · elbows off the floor



FRONT BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Rectus abdominis** · the front abs

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

ALSO

**Obliques** · the sides of the waist

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Noticeably harder in the abs. Nothing in the neck.

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Set up exactly as the basic curl-up: one knee bent, hands under the low back.
2. Brace, lift head and shoulders an inch.
3. Now float both elbows off the floor while you hold.
4. Ten seconds, lower everything, rest three. Switch the bent knee halfway.

## WATCH FOR

Lifting higher to compensate. Keep it tiny.

Neck strain means you went too high.

**Easier:** Drop back to the basic curl-up.

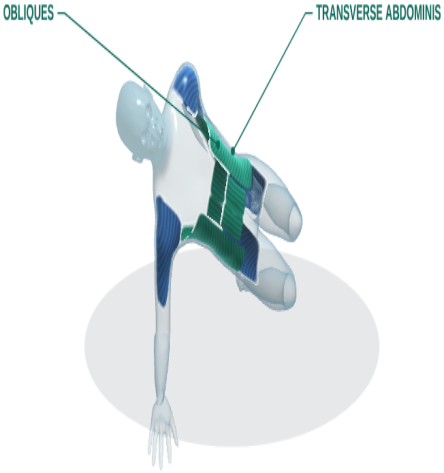
In the session: Hold 10s, rest 3s. Repeat. Switch bent knee halfway.

# Side Plank · Knees

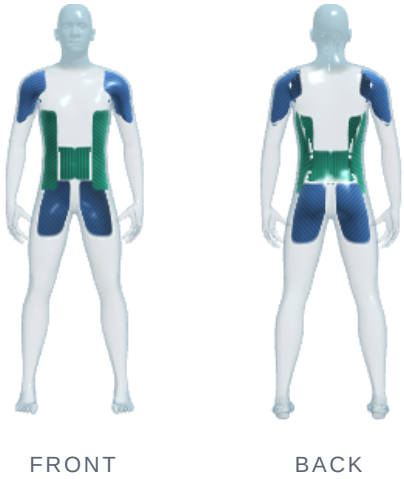
A side plank from the knees. It loads the obliques and the deep spine stabilizers on one side at a time, which is the safest way to build lateral core strength.




**Start** Hips on the floor




**End** Hips up · one straight line




## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Obliques** · the sides of the waist

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

ALSO

**Shoulders** · deltoids and rotator cuff

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

The side of the waist that's facing the floor. Some work in the shoulder.

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Lie on your side, knees bent to ninety degrees, elbow directly under the shoulder.
2. Put the top hand on your hip.
3. Lift the hips until knee, hip and shoulder make one straight line.
4. Hold ten seconds, rest three, repeat. Switch sides halfway.

## WATCH FOR

Hips sag backward or drop.

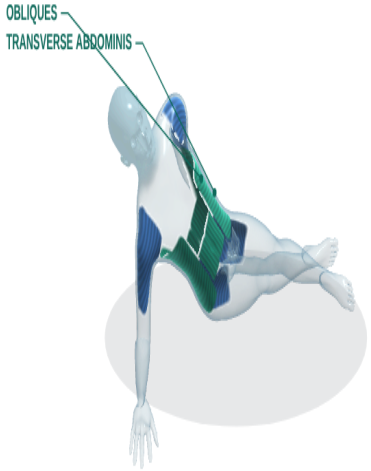
Elbow drifts out from under the shoulder, which makes the shoulder hurt.

**Easier:** Hold five seconds, or rest the top forearm on the floor in front for support.

In the session: Hold 10s, rest 3s, repeat. Switch sides halfway.

# Side Plank · Feet

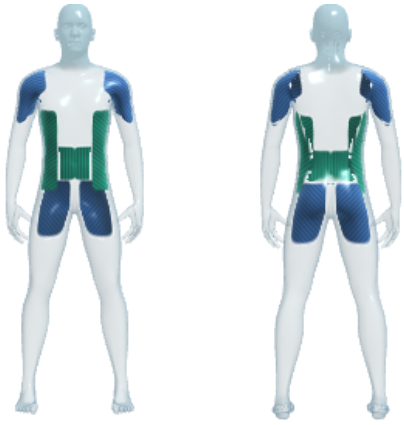
The full side plank, from the feet. Same muscles as the knee version, with the whole body as the lever.




**Start** Hips on the floor




**End** Hips up · ankle to head



FRONT BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Obliques** · the sides of the waist

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

ALSO

**Shoulders** · deltoids and rotator cuff

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

## HOW TO DO IT

1. On your side, legs straight, top foot in front of the bottom one.
2. Elbow under the shoulder, top hand on your hip.
3. Lift the hips. One straight line from ankle to head.
4. Hold ten seconds, rest three, repeat. Switch sides halfway.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Waist, hip, and the outside of the bottom hip working to keep you level.

## WATCH FOR

Hips sagging. The moment they do, drop to the knees.

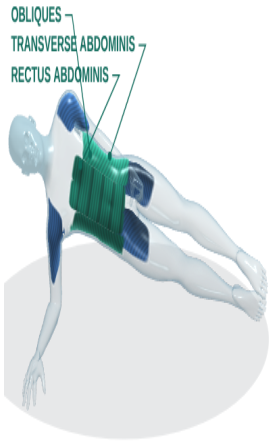
Rolling the chest toward the floor.

**Easier:** Go back to the knees for the second half of each hold.

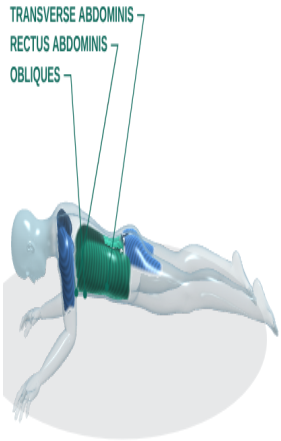
In the session: Hold 10s, rest 3s, repeat. Switch sides halfway.

# Side Plank · Roll

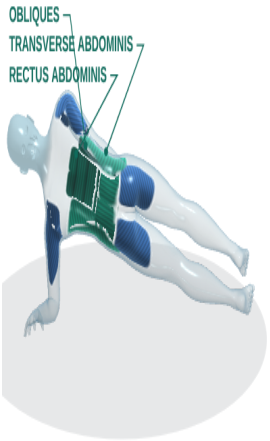
Roll from a side plank through a front plank to the other side without the hips dropping. Teaches the core to stay braced while the body turns.




**Start** Side plank · right forearm




**Then** Roll · both forearms, hips level




**End** Side plank · left forearm



FRONT



BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Obliques** · the sides of the waist

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

**Rectus abdominis** · the front abs

ALSO

**Shoulders** · deltoids and rotator cuff

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Start in a full side plank, elbow under the shoulder.
2. Hold ten seconds.
3. Rotate onto both forearms into a front plank. Keep the hips at the same height.
4. Continue rolling onto the other elbow into the opposite side plank. Hold ten seconds. Repeat.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Both sides of the waist in turn, with the front abs holding during the roll.

## WATCH FOR

Hips dip during the transition.

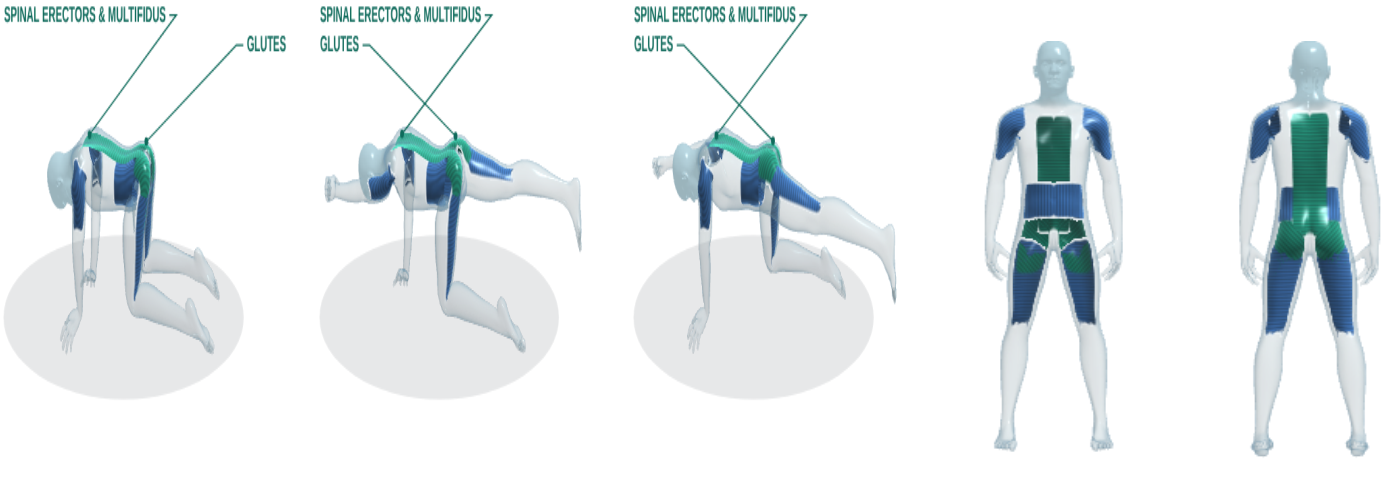
Rushing the roll.

**Easier:** Do the roll from the knees.

In the session: Hold 10s, roll through front plank to the other side, hold 10s. Repeat.

# Bird Dog

On all fours, reach one arm forward and the opposite leg back. Named for the pointer-dog pose. It trains the back muscles to hold the spine still while the limbs move.




**Start** All fours · back flat

**Then** Reach arm and opposite leg

**Other side** Reach arm and opposite leg

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Spinal erectors & multifidus** · the low-back muscles either side of the spine

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

ALSO

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

**Shoulders** · deltoids and rotator cuff

**Hamstrings** · back of the thigh

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Hands under shoulders, knees under hips, back flat.
2. Brace the abs lightly.
3. Slide one leg back until straight, toes pointing down. Reach the opposite arm forward with a fist.
4. Hold five seconds. Squeeze the glute of the extended leg.
5. Return without touching down and switch sides.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Glute of the back leg, the low back muscles working to stay level, light ab tension.

## WATCH FOR

Hips rotate or the back arches when the leg lifts.

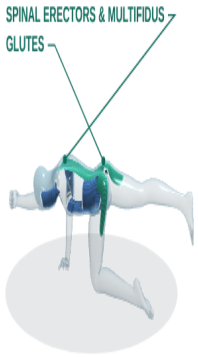
Kicking the leg high. Level with the body is enough.

**Easier:** Lift only the arm, or only the leg, for the first week.

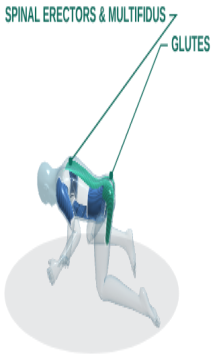
In the session: Reach, hold 5s, return. Alternate sides for the whole time.

# Bird Dog · Sweep

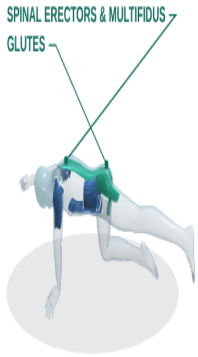
The bird dog with a sweep: after the hold, draw the elbow and knee together under the body, then extend again. More time under tension and a bigger stability challenge.




**Start** Reach




**Then** Sweep elbow to knee




**Other side** Reach




**Other side · sweep** Sweep elbow to knee



FRONT



BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Spinal erectors & multifidus** · the low-back muscles either side of the spine

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

ALSO

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

**Shoulders** · deltoids and rotator cuff

**Rectus abdominis** · the front abs

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Set up as for the bird dog and extend arm and opposite leg.
2. Hold five seconds.
3. Sweep the elbow and knee toward each other under your body, slowly.
4. Extend again without touching the floor. Alternate sides.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Same as the bird dog with more work in the abs during the sweep.

## WATCH FOR

Back moves during the sweep.

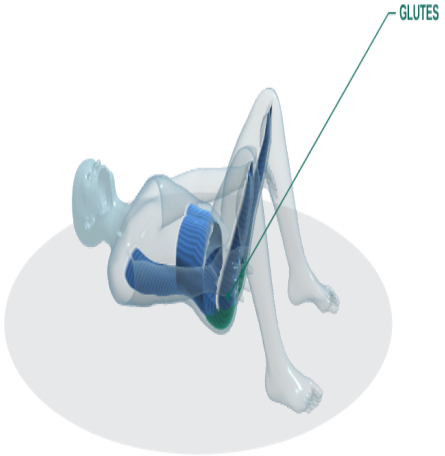
Speed. If you can't keep the back still, stop the set.

**Easier:** Drop the sweep; do the plain bird dog.

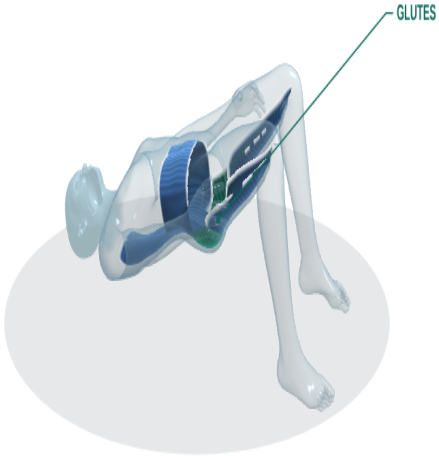
In the session: Reach, hold 5s, sweep elbow to knee under the body, extend again. Alternate.

# Glute Bridge

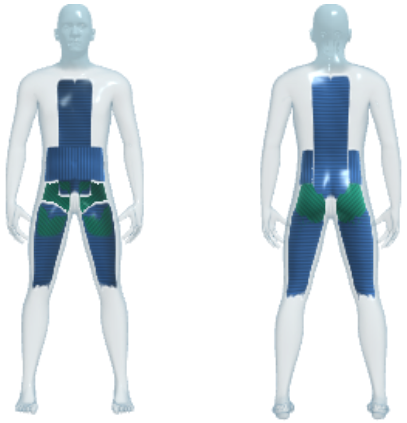
Lying on your back, drive the hips up until the body is a straight line from shoulders to knees. It wakes up the glutes, which usually go quiet in people who sit all day and leave the low back to do their job.




**Start** Lie down · feet flat




**End** Squeeze and lift



FRONT BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

ALSO

**Hamstrings** · back of the thigh

**Spinal erectors & multifidus** · the low-back muscles either side of the spine

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Lie on your back, knees bent, feet flat and close to the hips.
2. Brace the abs so the ribs don't flare.
3. Push through the heels and squeeze the glutes to lift the hips.
4. Stop when hips are in line with knees and shoulders. Squeeze two seconds. Lower in two.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Glutes, not the low back. If the back is doing it, you're arching too high.

## WATCH FOR

Arching the low back to go higher.

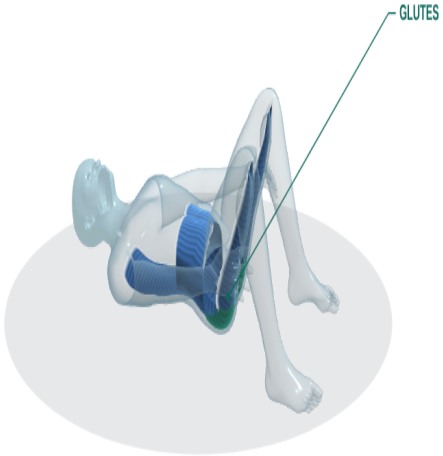
Pushing through the toes.

**Easier:** Smaller lift; hold a pillow between the knees to keep the glutes honest.

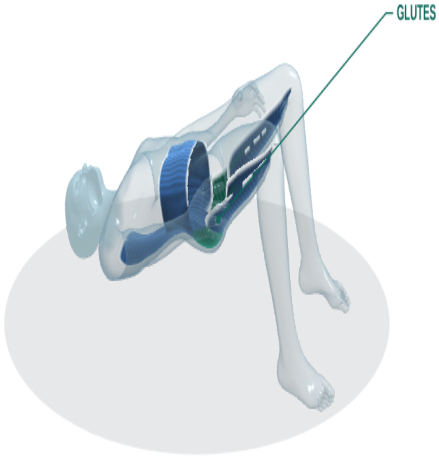
In the session: Up 2s, squeeze 2s at the top, down 2s. Reps for the whole time.

# Glute Bridge · Hold

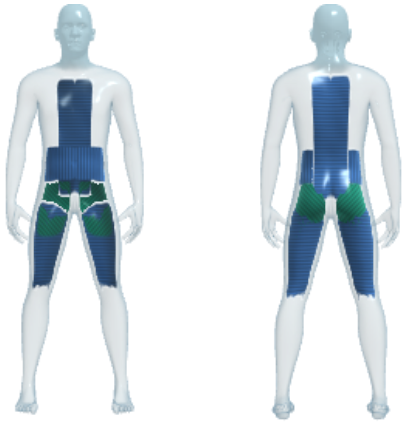
The glute bridge held at the top. Isometric work builds endurance in the glutes and teaches them to stay on while you breathe.




**Start** Lie down · feet flat




**End** Hold at the top



FRONT BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

ALSO

**Hamstrings** · back of the thigh

**Spinal erectors & multifidus** · the low-back muscles either side of the spine

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Set up as for the glute bridge.
2. Lift to the top position.
3. Hold fifteen seconds. Keep breathing. Keep the glutes squeezed.
4. Lower, rest five, repeat.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Glute burn. Hamstrings may join in.

## WATCH FOR

Holding the breath.

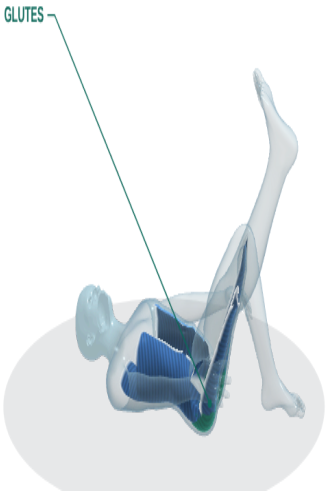
Hamstring cramp: move the feet an inch further from the hips.

**Easier:** Hold eight seconds.

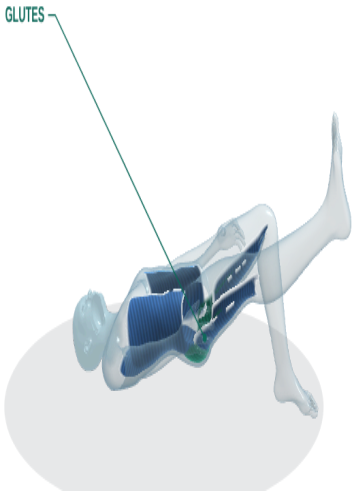
In the session: Hold 15s, rest 5s. Repeat.

# Single-Leg Bridge

The bridge on one leg. The planted glute has to lift and level the whole pelvis alone, which exposes and fixes side-to-side weakness.




**Start** One leg extended · thighs level




**End** Lift with the planted glute



FRONT BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

ALSO

**Hamstrings** · back of the thigh

**Spinal erectors & multifidus** · the low-back muscles either side of the spine

**Obliques** · the sides of the waist

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Bridge position, one foot flat.
2. Extend the other leg straight, thigh level with the planted one.
3. Lift with the planted glute. Hips stay level.
4. Up two, hold two, down two. Switch legs halfway.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Planted-side glute working hard. Pelvis level.

## WATCH FOR

The free-side hip drops. That means the glute isn't ready yet.

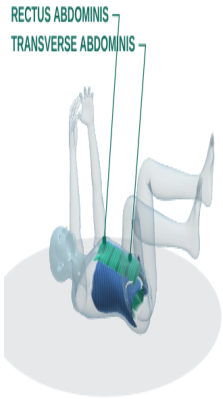
Low back takes over.

**Easier:** Keep both feet down and shift most of the weight to one foot.

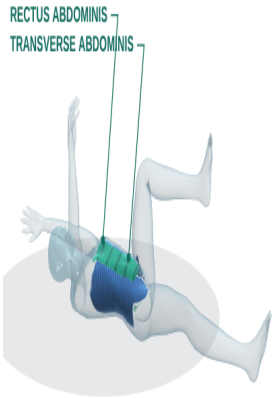
In the session: Up 2s, hold 2s, down 2s. Switch legs halfway.

# Dead Bug

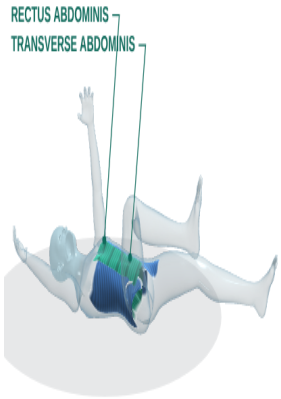
Lying on your back with arms and knees up, lower the opposite arm and leg toward the floor while the low back stays glued down. Named for the pose of an upturned beetle. Teaches the core to brace while the limbs move.




**Start** Arms up · knees over hips




**Then** Lower opposite arm and leg




**Other side** Lower opposite arm and leg



FRONT



BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

**Rectus abdominis** · the front abs

ALSO

**Hip flexors** · the front of the hip

**Obliques** · the sides of the waist

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Lie on your back. Arms straight up. Knees over hips, shins level.
2. Press the low back into the floor (the pelvic tilt).
3. Breathe out and lower one arm overhead and the opposite leg toward the floor, slowly.
4. Stop before the back lifts. Return. Switch sides.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Low abs working to keep the back down. Nothing in the back itself.

## WATCH FOR

The low back lifts off the floor. Shorten the range.

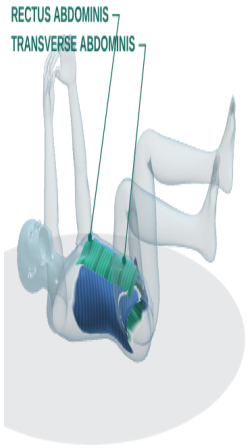
Going fast.

**Easier:** Move only the legs, or only the arms.

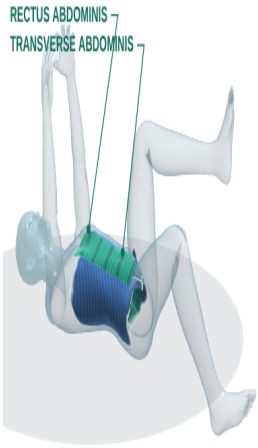
In the session: Slow reps, alternating, for the whole time.

# Dead Bug · Heel Tap

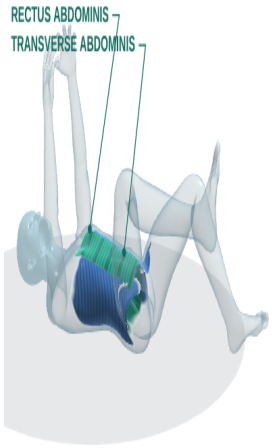
The dead bug with a heel tap: the leg stays bent and the heel touches the floor. Shorter lever, same bracing skill, easier to control.




**Start** Tabletop




**Then** Tap the heel down




**Other side** Tap the heel down



FRONT



BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

**Rectus abdominis** · the front abs

ALSO

**Hip flexors** · the front of the hip

**Obliques** · the sides of the waist

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Same start: arms up, knees over hips, low back pressed down.
2. Lower one heel to tap the floor, knee still bent.
3. Return. Alternate legs. Arms stay up, or lower the opposite arm.
4. Breathe out as the heel goes down.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Low abs. If the low back is doing the work, press it down harder.

## WATCH FOR

Back arches.

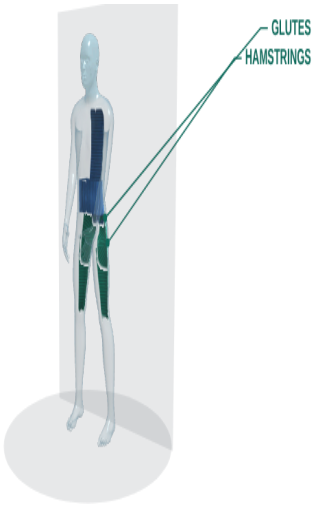
Thigh swings instead of lowering under control.

**Easier:** Tap closer to the body.

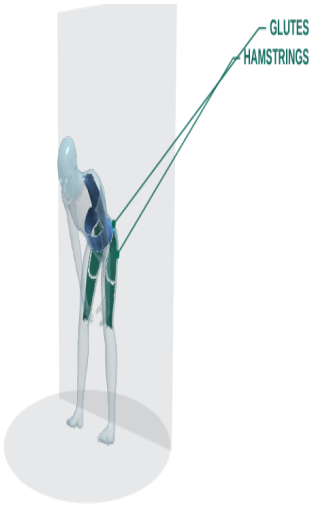
In the session: Slow reps, alternating, for the whole time.

# Wall Hip Hinge

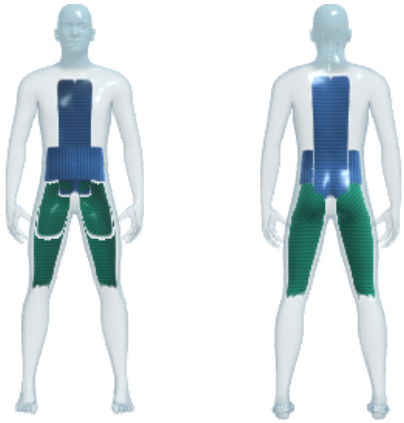
Push the hips back to touch a wall while the back stays flat. This is how to bend without rounding the spine, and it's the single most useful skill for picking things up.




**Start** Stand tall · hands on thighs




**End** Hips back to the wall




## WORKS

### PRIMARY

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

**Hamstrings** · back of the thigh

### ALSO

**Spinal erectors & multifidus** · the low-back muscles either side of the spine

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

A stretch in the hamstrings on the way down, the glutes on the way up.

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Stand a foot in front of a wall, facing away. Feet hip width. Knees soft.
2. Hands on thighs. Brace the abs lightly.
3. Push the hips straight back until they touch the wall. The chest comes forward; the back stays flat.
4. Squeeze the glutes to stand up tall. Repeat slowly.

## WATCH FOR

The back rounds. Think 'chest up'.

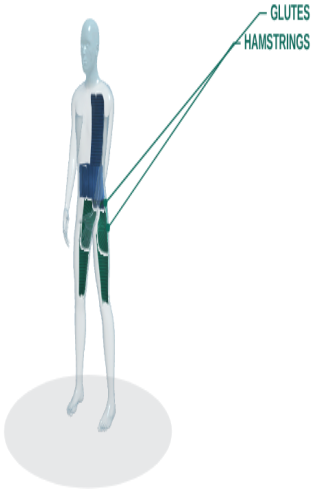
Bending the knees into a squat instead of sending the hips back.

**Easier:** Stand closer to the wall.

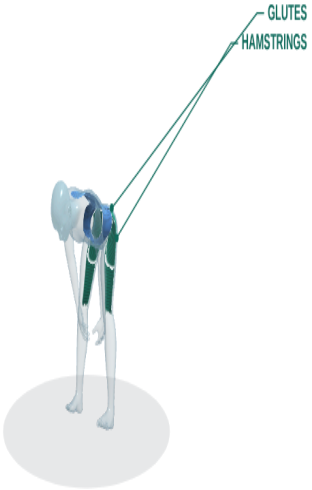
In the session: Slow reps for the whole time. Hips back, chest up, stand tall.

# Hip Hinge · Reach

The hip hinge without the wall, reaching the hands down the thighs. Same pattern, more range.




**Start** Stand tall




**End** Hinge · hands slide down



FRONT



BACK

## WORKS

### PRIMARY

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

**Hamstrings** · back of the thigh

### ALSO

**Spinal erectors & multifidus** · the low-back muscles either side of the spine

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Stand tall, knees soft, hands on thighs.
2. Push the hips back; let the hands slide toward the knees.
3. Keep the back flat and the neck in line with the spine.
4. Drive the glutes forward to stand. Repeat slowly.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Hamstrings loading, glutes standing you up.

## WATCH FOR

Rounding the back to reach further. Stop where the hamstrings stop you.

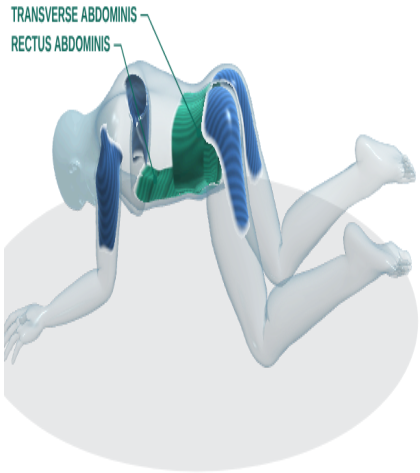
Looking up and craning the neck.

**Easier:** Hinge only as far as the hands reach mid-thigh.

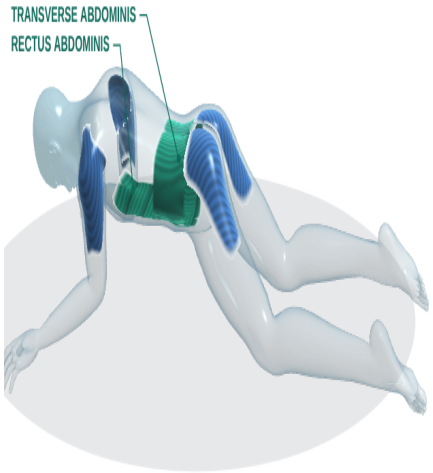
In the session: Slow reps for the whole time.

# Front Plank · Knees

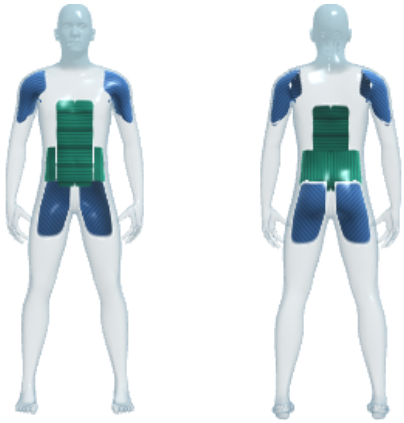
A front plank on forearms and knees. The body is held straight against gravity, which trains the whole front of the core to resist sagging.




**Start** Forearms and knees down




**End** Hold · one line knees to head




## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Rectus abdominis** · the front abs

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

ALSO

**Shoulders** · deltoids and rotator cuff

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Abs working. Shoulders mildly. Low back quiet.

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Forearms on the floor, elbows under shoulders, knees down.
2. Squeeze the glutes. Tuck the ribs down. Brace the abs.
3. Make one straight line from knees to head.
4. Hold ten seconds, rest three, repeat.

## WATCH FOR

Hips sag or pike up.

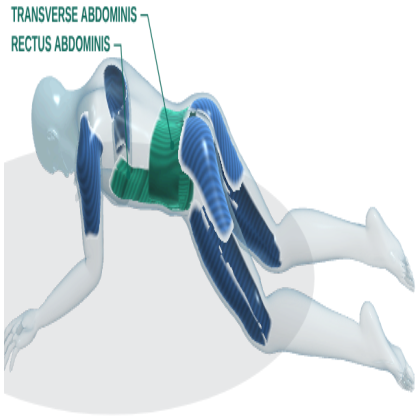
Shoulders shrug toward the ears.

**Easier:** Hold five seconds or do it on a bench or step.

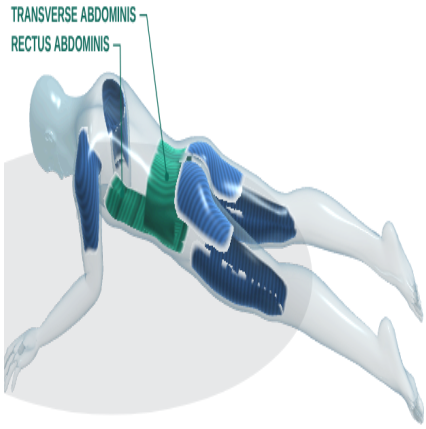
In the session: Hold 10s, rest 3s, repeat.

# Front Plank

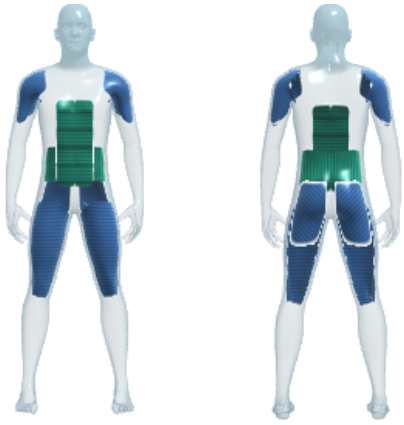
The full front plank on forearms and toes. The standard isometric core hold.




**Start** Knees down




**End** Up on the toes · hold



FRONT BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Rectus abdominis** · the front abs

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

ALSO

**Shoulders** · deltoids and rotator cuff

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

**Quadriceps** · front of the thigh

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Forearms down, elbows under shoulders, toes tucked.
2. Glutes tight, ribs down, push the floor away.
3. One line from heels to head.
4. Hold fifteen seconds, rest five, repeat.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Abs and glutes. If the low back feels it, drop to the knees.

## WATCH FOR

Hips sag. Stop and go to knees.

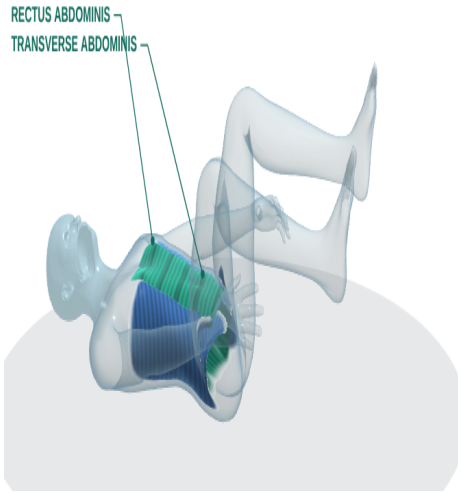
Head drops; look at the floor just ahead of the hands.

**Easier:** Finish each hold on the knees.

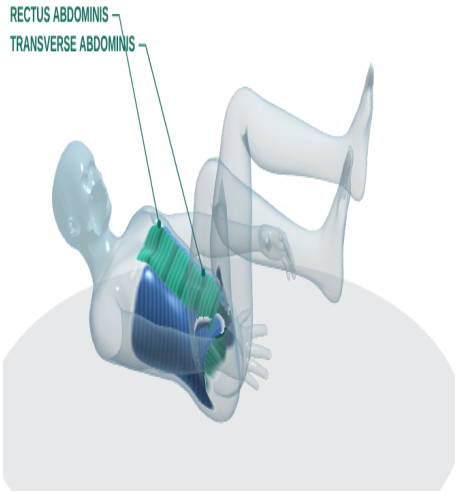
In the session: Hold 15s, rest 5s, repeat.

# Hollow Hold · Bent

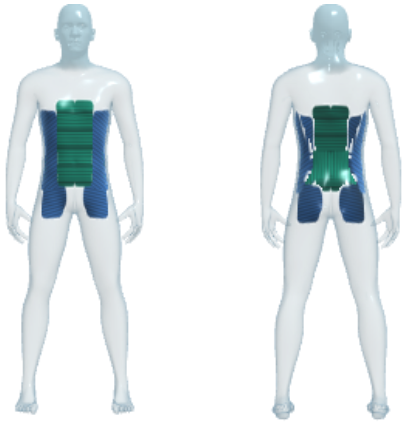
Lying on your back, press the low back flat and lift shoulders and bent knees an inch. A gymnastics basic in its easiest form. Builds the braced position every other lift uses.




**Start** Knees up · back flat




**End** Shoulders an inch up



FRONT BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Rectus abdominis** · the front abs

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

ALSO

**Hip flexors** · the front of the hip

**Obliques** · the sides of the waist

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Lie on your back. Press the low back flat.
2. Lift the knees over the hips, shins level.
3. Lift the shoulders an inch, arms by your sides an inch off the floor.
4. Hold ten seconds, rest five, repeat.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Whole front of the trunk working. Low back pressed flat.

## WATCH FOR

Low back arches off the floor. Pull the knees closer to the chest.

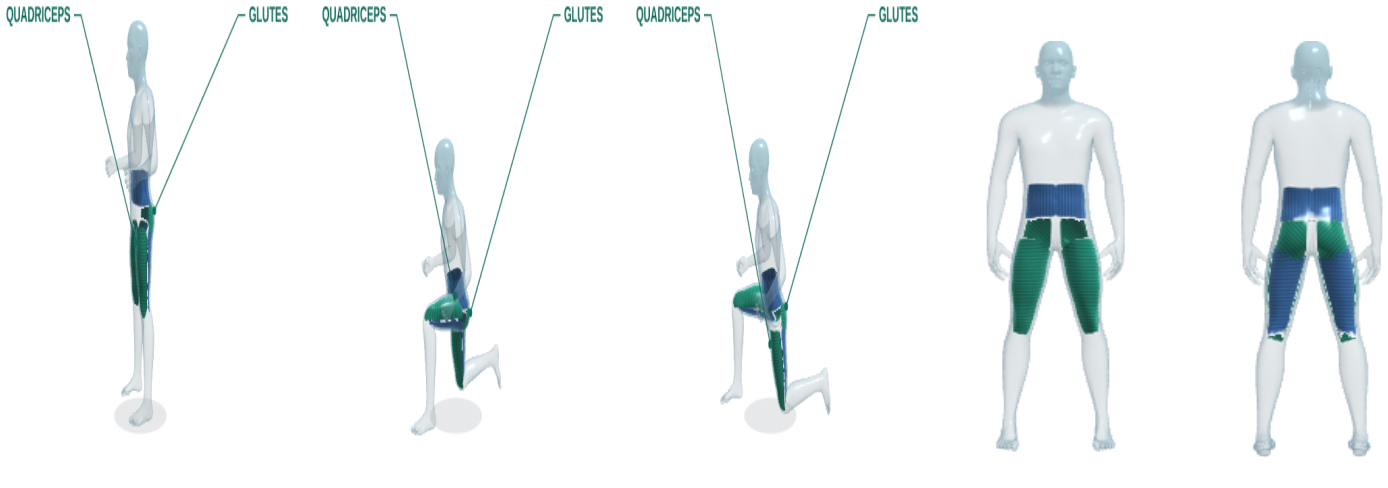
Neck strain from pulling the head up.

**Easier:** Keep the shoulders down and only lift the knees.

In the session: Hold 10s, rest 5s, repeat.

# Reverse Lunge

Step one foot back and lower the back knee toward the floor, then push through the front heel to stand. Trains the glutes and legs one side at a time without loading the spine.




**Start** Stand · hands on hips

**Then** Step back and lower

**Other side** Step back and lower

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

**Quadriceps** · front of the thigh

ALSO

**Hamstrings** · back of the thigh

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Stand tall, hands on hips.
2. Step one foot back a comfortable distance.
3. Lower the back knee toward the floor, chest tall.
4. Push through the front heel to stand. Alternate.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Front-leg glute and thigh. Torso stays upright.

## WATCH FOR

Leaning forward.

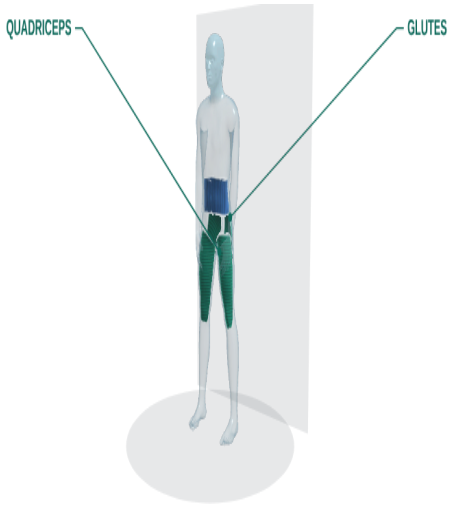
Front knee caving inward.

**Easier:** Shorter step and don't go as low; hold a wall or chair.

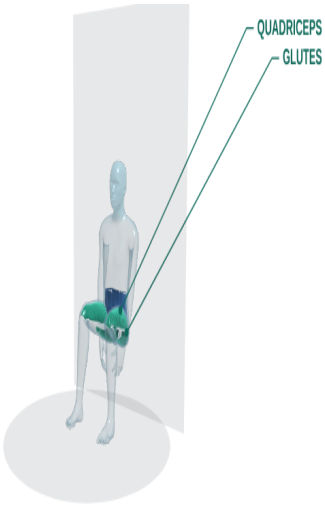
In the session: Slow reps, alternating. Hands on hips.

# Wall Sit

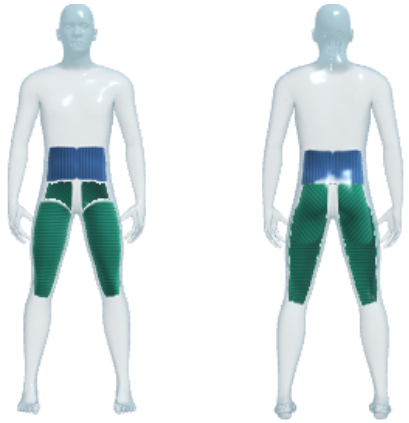
Sit against a wall with thighs near level and hold. Builds leg endurance with the spine supported, which lets you stand and walk longer without the back fatiguing.




**Start** Back on the wall




**End** Slide down · thighs level




## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Quadriceps** · front of the thigh

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

ALSO

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Thighs burning. Back comfortable against the wall.

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Back flat against a wall, feet about a foot and a half out.
2. Slide down until thighs are near level. Knees over ankles.
3. Brace the abs. Breathe.
4. Hold twenty seconds, rest ten, repeat.

## WATCH FOR

Knees past the toes.

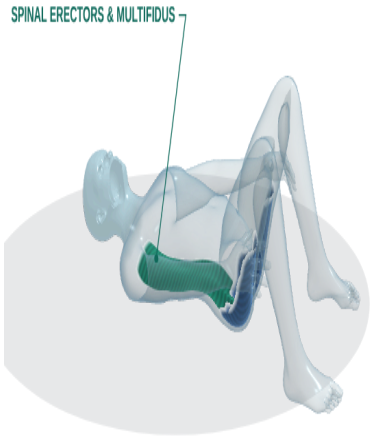
Going lower than the knees like.

**Easier:** Don't go as low.

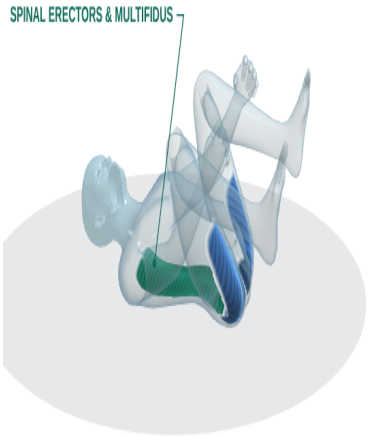
In the session: Hold 20s, rest 10s, repeat.

# Knees to Chest

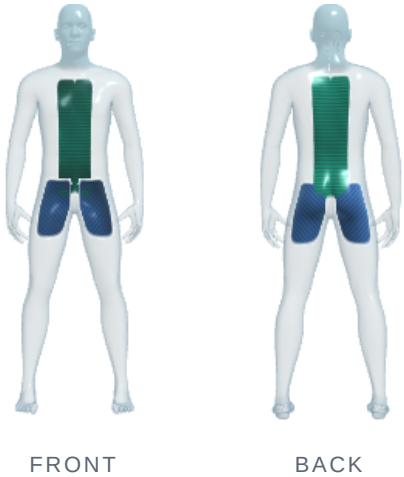
Hug both knees to the chest and breathe. A gentle release for the low back after it has worked.




**Start** Lie down




**End** Hug the knees in




## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Spinal erectors & multifidus** · the low-back muscles either side of the spine

ALSO

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Mild stretch in the low back and glutes. Relief, not strain.

**Easier:** One knee at a time.

In the session: Hug and breathe. Slow.

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Lie on your back.
2. Pull both knees in with your hands.
3. Let the low back relax and lengthen. Rock gently side to side.
4. Breathe slowly for the whole time.

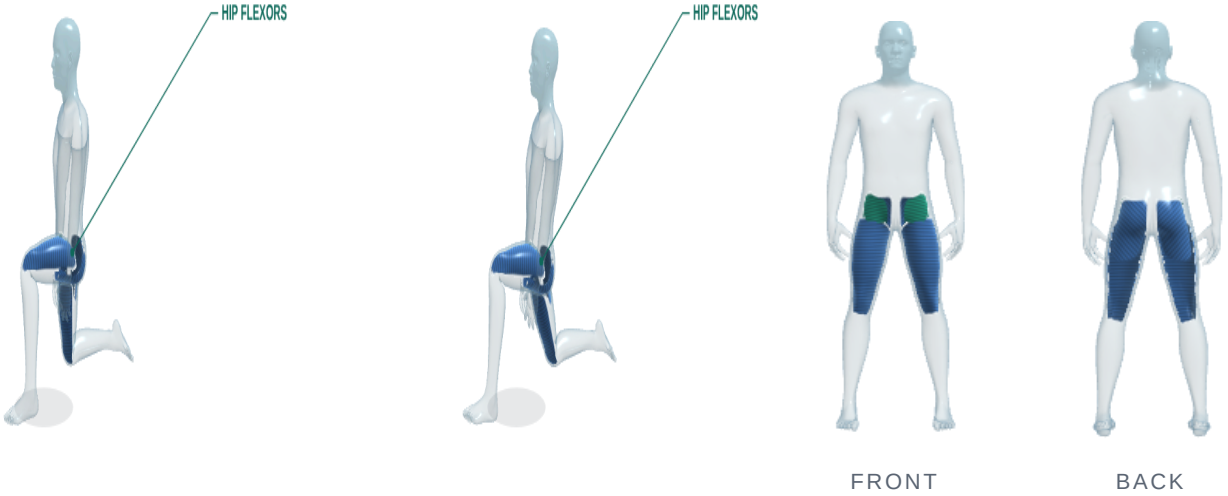
## WATCH FOR

Pulling into pain.

Lifting the head and tensing the neck.

# Half-Kneel Hip Flexor

A half-kneeling stretch for the front of the hip. Tight hip flexors from sitting pull the pelvis forward and push the belly out; this stretch is part of the posture fix.




**Start** Half kneel

**End** Tuck the tailbone · shift forward

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Hip flexors** · the front of the hip

ALSO

**Quadriceps** · front of the thigh

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Front of the hip and thigh on the kneeling side.

## HOW TO DO IT

1. One knee on the floor, the other foot forward, both knees at ninety degrees.
2. Tuck the tailbone and squeeze the glute on the kneeling side.
3. Shift forward slightly until you feel the front of the kneeling hip stretch.
4. Thirty seconds each side.

## WATCH FOR

Leaning forward and arching the back instead of tucking.

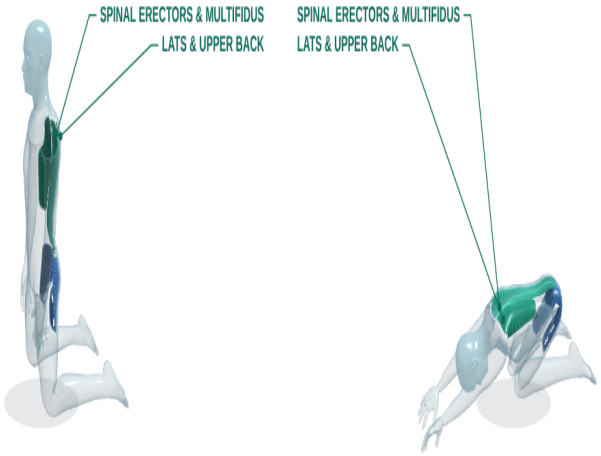
Letting the front knee drift past the ankle.

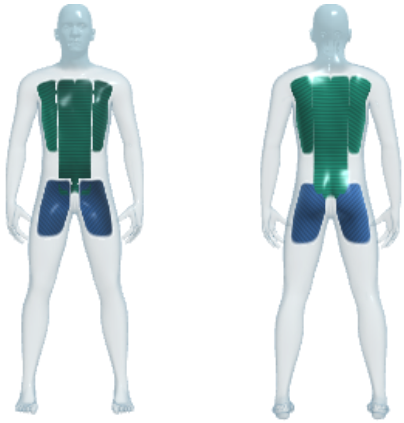
**Easier:** Put a cushion under the knee and shift less.

In the session: 30s each side.

# Child's Pose

Kneel, sit back toward the heels and fold forward with arms long. A resting position that lengthens the back and lets the breath settle.




**Start** Kneel · sit back

**End** Fold forward · arms long

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Spinal erectors & multifidus** · the low-back muscles either side of the spine

**Lats & upper back** · the broad muscles behind the ribs

ALSO

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Kneel with the knees wide, big toes together.
2. Sit back toward the heels.
3. Walk the hands forward and rest the forehead down.
4. Breathe into the back of the ribs.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Length along the whole back. Calm.

## WATCH FOR

Forcing the hips down.

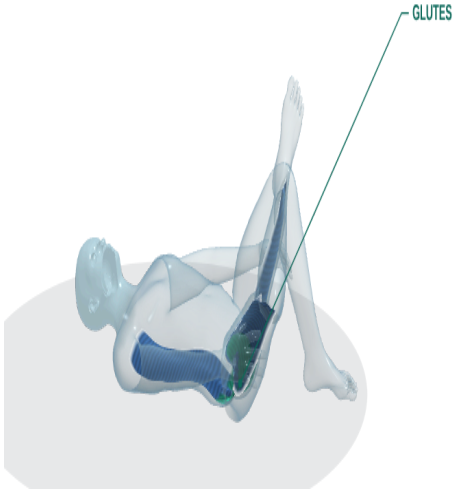
Holding tension in the shoulders.

**Easier:** Put a cushion between heels and hips, or rest on the forearms.

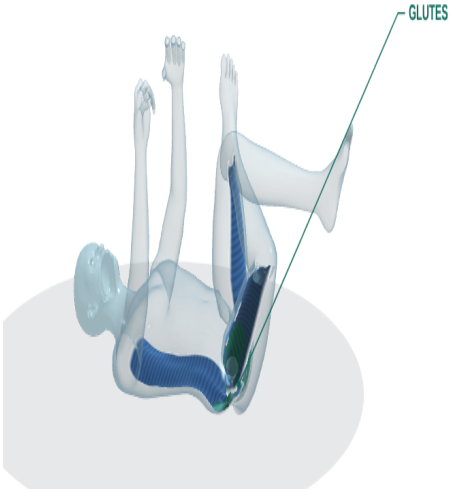
In the session: Breathe slowly. Let the back lengthen.

# Figure-4 Stretch

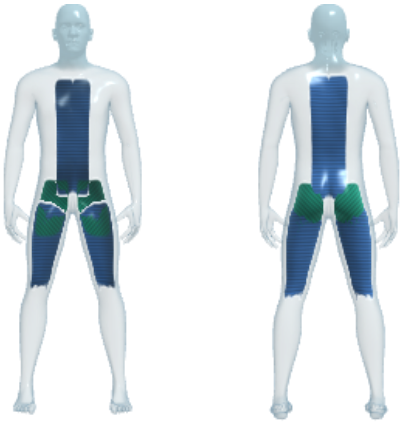
Lying down, cross one ankle over the opposite knee and pull that thigh in. Stretches the deep hip rotators and glute, which tighten up and refer pain into the low back.




**Start** Ankle on the opposite knee




**End** Pull the thigh in



FRONT BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

ALSO

**Hamstrings** · back of the thigh

**Spinal erectors & multifidus** · the low-back muscles either side of the spine

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Lie on your back, knees bent.
2. Place one ankle on the opposite knee.
3. Reach through and pull the supporting thigh toward you.
4. Head down, back flat. Thirty seconds each side.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Deep in the hip and glute of the crossed leg.

## WATCH FOR

Lifting the head and shoulders to reach.

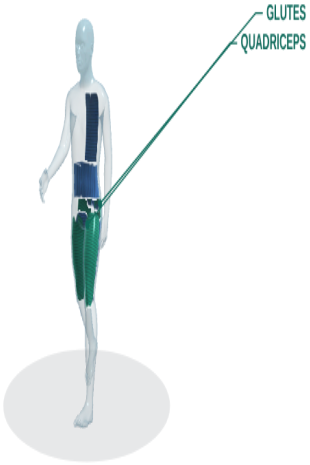
Pushing the crossed knee away to get more; let it rest.

**Easier:** Keep the supporting foot on the floor and just push the crossed knee gently.

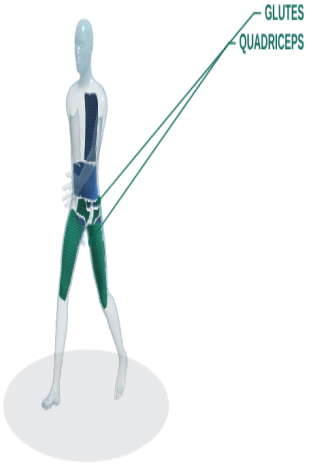
In the session: 30s each side.

# Walk

A brisk walk after the session. Walking is the lowest-risk, best-evidenced thing for both a sore back and a soft middle. The timer gives you a minute to get your shoes on.




Start




End



FRONT



BACK

## WORKS

PRIMARY

**Glutes** · the buttock muscles that extend the hip

**Quadriceps** · front of the thigh

ALSO

**Hamstrings** · back of the thigh

**Transverse abdominis** · the deep corset muscle that braces the spine

**Spinal erectors & multifidus** · the low-back muscles either side of the spine

## HOW TO DO IT

1. Stand tall, eyes ahead.
2. Swing the arms. Breathe through the nose.
3. Aim for twenty to thirty minutes, any pace that lets you talk.
4. Count it even if it's split into two walks.

## YOU SHOULD FEEL

Warm, loose, easier breathing by the end.

## WATCH FOR

Walking with the phone in hand and the head down.

Skipping it because it isn't 'exercise'. It is.

**Easier:** Ten minutes is still a win.

In the session: Not timed here. Aim for 20–30 minutes today, any pace.